

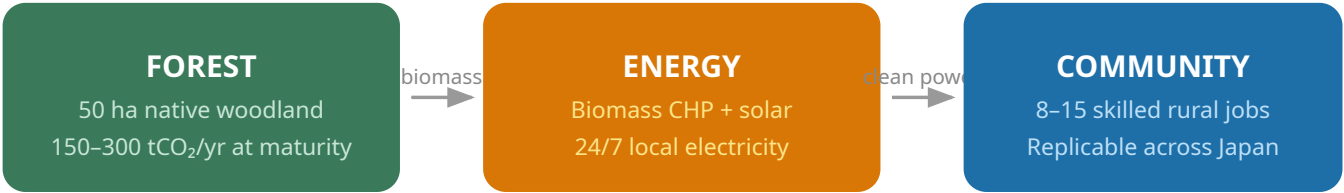
PROJECT DOCUMENT

Mitsue Project

Conversation Brief — for Yuko Koshiba



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Author	Rob Oudendijk



Mission

The Mitsue Project is creating an open, replicable model for rural revitalisation that combines forest restoration, renewable energy, AI infrastructure, and community development. Designed so that other rural communities in Japan can adopt and adapt the model.

Mitsue Village provides an ideal demonstration site due to its abundant forest resources, declining population, and strong commitment to sustainable regional revitalisation.

PROJECT AT A GLANCE

- 📍 Mitsue Village, Nara
- 🌲 50 ha forest restoration
- ⚡ Biomass CHP + solar + EV charging
- 📶 Community digital infrastructure
- 🔓 Open-source & replicable

"Our goal is not simply to build a successful project in Mitsue, but to create a financing and governance model that can accelerate rural revitalisation across Japan."

Three Metrics

	Theme	Metric	Why it matters
👥	Community	8-15 permanent skilled rural jobs by Year 5; forest landowner income from Year 2; open playbook adoptable by any rural municipality (<i>projection</i>)	Reverses depopulation; creates lasting economic resilience; replicable across Japan
🌲	Environment	Restore 50 ha of plantation forest into resilient native woodland over 25 years. Sequestration: 150-300 tCO₂/yr at maturity (<i>projection</i>)	Measurable natural capital creation; J-Credit income for landowners; biodiversity recovery
⚡	Energy	24/7 locally generated renewable electricity powering critical community infrastructure. Baseline data center load: ~79 MWh/yr; full village system sized in Phase 1 feasibility study (<i>projection</i>)	Community energy resilience; eliminates grid dependency; keeps services running during blackouts

Why Philanthropy Matters Here

Traditional project finance cannot reach this project alone, for structural reasons:

- **Long investment horizon** — forest restoration operates on a 25-year timescale; equity investors need returns on a 5–7 year horizon
- **Open-source by design** — everything built will be documented and published openly, so the methodology cannot be monetised by the project that creates it; benefits extend to every community that adopts the model
- **High public benefit, diffuse returns** — the largest gains (ecological recovery, rural employment, replicability) flow to the community and future communities, not to any single funder
- **Government grant leverage** — philanthropic capital in Phase 0 unlocks the MoE's 地域脱炭素移行・再エネ推進交付金, which covers **2/3 to 3/4 of Phase 1–2 energy capex**; realising this opportunity requires a capable operating partner
- **Designed to become self-sustaining** — the project reaches operating surplus by approximately Year 5 and then funds further forest and community investment from its own revenue; philanthropy exits into a financially independent model

Questions for Discussion

Rather than a funding ask, these are the questions this meeting is meant to explore:

1. **Ecosystem positioning** — How would you position a project like this within Japan's current philanthropy landscape? Which types of philanthropic partners do you think would most naturally align with a project like this?
2. **Governance** — For a project spanning a non-profit mission entity, a for-profit operating company, a village government partner, and eventual open-source replication, what governance structure would you explore first to give philanthropic partners confidence?
3. **Impact horizon** — What metrics, verification methods, and reporting cadence would philanthropic partners typically expect over a 10–20 year commitment to a project of this kind?

The Mitsue Project · Mitsue Village (御杖村), Nara Prefecture, Japan
Rob Oudendijk · oudendijk.biz@gmail.com · 080-2260-5966

